TEXT TYPE · B2 · USUALLY THE SHORT TASK

# The e-mail

*Clear purpose, proper format*

| Word count | Register | Subject line | Sign-off |
|---|---|---|---|
| **~250 words (225–275)** | **Usually formal** | **Required** | **Yours faithfully / sincerely** |

## STRUCTURE AND LAYOUT

**To:** – [recipient's e-mail]
**From:** – [your e-mail]
**Date:** – [date]
**Subject:** – [clear and descriptive]
**Dear Sir or Madam, / Dear Mr/Ms [Name],**
**Introduction** – state why you are writing in the first sentence
**Body paragraphs 1–3** – one content point per paragraph
**Conclusion** – restate purpose, expected response
**Yours faithfully, / Yours sincerely,** – faithfully = name unknown; sincerely = name known

## DO'S AND DON'TS

### DO

- Include all header elements (To, From, Date, Subject)
- State your reason for writing in the first sentence
- Use formal language – no slang
- Use full forms (do not instead of don't)
- Leave a blank line between paragraphs
- Match greeting to closing (Dear Sir → Yours faithfully)
- Use "softer" phrases when criticising: I would like to point out, it seems to me

### DON'T

- No contractions in formal e-mails
- No emojis or emoticons
- No casual greetings (Hey, Hi there)
- Don't use an unprofessional e-mail address
- Don't forget a subject line
- Don't mix up faithfully/sincerely

## WEAKER VS. STRONGER

### WEAKER

*Hi! Your headphones broke after two days and I want my money back, thanks.*

### STRONGER

*Dear Sir or Madam, I am writing to request a refund for the headphones I bought on 3 May, which stopped working after two days.*

**Why it matters.** A formal e-mail names its purpose in the first line and keeps a polite, formal register throughout. The casual version would be marked down for register and tone.

## KEY TIP

Faithfully vs. sincerely: "Dear Sir/Madam" (name unknown) → Yours faithfully. "Dear Mr/Ms Brown" (name known) → Yours sincerely. This mistake is easy to spot. If the task is an informal e-mail (to a friend, a host family, an exchange partner), the same rules apply the other way round: "Hi Anna," / "Dear Tom,", contractions are fine, and you close with "Best wishes" or "Take care". Read the task: the recipient decides the register.

## MODEL TEXT

**Complaint regarding Summer Language Course in Brighton** (~250 words · Formal register)

> **The task.** You recently attended a two-week summer language course in Brighton that did not match the advertisement. Write an e-mail of complaint to the language school.
>
> In your e-mail you should:
>
> - describe the problems with the classes
> - complain about the afternoon programme
> - explain how the staff reacted when you raised the problems
>
> Write around 250 words. The model follows the five-paragraph plan: introduction, one paragraph for each content point, conclusion.

Structure Language Text-specific

To: info@globalenglish.example
From: sarah.berger@email.example
Date: 10 April 2026
Subject: Complaint regarding Summer Language Course in Brighton[1]

**Dear Sir or Madam,**[2]

I am writing to express my dissatisfaction with[3] the two-week language course I attended at your Brighton school from 16 to 27 March 2026. Although[4] your website promised small class sizes and experienced teachers, my experience was far from what had been advertised[5].

To begin with,[6] the classes did not match your description: groups of up to 22 students made individual attention impossible. Furthermore,[7] our teacher changed three times during the course, and the final replacement had no formal teaching qualification. As a result,[8] several students felt they had not improved at all.

On top of this, the afternoon programme was very disappointing.[9] The brochure promised daily excursions and sports activities, but two of the trips were cancelled without notice, and on several afternoons we were simply left in an empty classroom with a film.

When I raised these problems with the reception staff,[10] I was simply told that nothing could be done, and none of the staff seemed willing to take responsibility. To make matters worse, the written complaint I handed in during the course was never answered.

I would therefore like to request[11] a partial refund of the course fees, as the services provided did not match the description on your website. I look forward to hearing from you within 14 days.[12] Should I not receive a satisfactory response[13], I will have no choice but to share my experience on public review platforms.

Yours faithfully,[14]
Sarah Berger

## WHAT THE EXAMINER NOTICES IN THIS MODEL

The numbers match the marked passages in the model text.

1. **Header – all 4 elements required**: *"To: info@globalenglish.example From: sarah.berger@email.example Date: 10 April 2026 Subject: Complaint regardi..."*
2. **Formal greeting (name unknown)**: *"Dear Sir or Madam,"*
3. **Set phrase – complaint opener**: *"I am writing to express my dissatisfaction with"*
4. **Concession – B2 linking**: *"Although"*
5. **Formal understatement – effective in complaints**: *"far from what had been advertised"*
6. **Content point 1 – problems with the classes**: *"To begin with,"*
7. **B2 linking word**: *"Furthermore,"*

8. **Linking word (cause and effect)**: *"As a result,"*
9. **Content point 2 – a new complaint, a new paragraph**: *"On top of this, the afternoon programme was very disappointing."*
10. **Content point 3 – how the staff reacted**: *"When I raised these problems with the reception staff,"*
11. **Clear, specific demand**: *"I would therefore like to request"*
12. **Sets a deadline – professional and firm**: *"I look forward to hearing from you within 14 days."*
13. **Formal conditional – firm but polite**: *"Should I not receive a satisfactory response"*
14. **Correct sign-off (Dear Sir → faithfully)**: *"Yours faithfully,"*

## USEFUL PHRASES

### Complaint openers

- I am writing to express my dissatisfaction with...
- I am writing to complain about...
- I would like to draw your attention to...
- I was appalled to find...

### Application openers

- I am writing to apply for the position of... as advertised in...
- I am writing with reference to your advertisement...
- I believe I am suitable for the position as I...

### Letter to the editor openers

- I am writing in response to the article on..., which appeared in... on [date].
- I have just read your article on... and I feel I must respond.
- You raised some issues which I feel strongly about.

### Closings (all sub-types)

- I look forward to hearing from you at your earliest convenience.
- I look forward to receiving the information requested.
- I am available for an interview at your convenience.
- Thank you for your cooperation in correcting this matter.

## THE FOUR SUB-TYPES

### Letter / E-mail of Complaint

You are unhappy with a product, service, or experience and you want something done about it. Stay firm but professional, never aggressive.

Use the standard e-mail header (To/From/Date/Subject). State your reason in the first sentence. Describe problems clearly in the body. End with a specific, reasonable demand.

**Tip.** A complaint shows whether you can be firm without being rude. "I am writing to express my dissatisfaction" works much better than "Your service was awful." Examiners look for a calm, professional tone.

### Letter / E-mail of Application

You are applying for a job, internship, volunteer position, or course. Be specific and confident, and show the employer why you are the right person.

Standard e-mail header. First paragraph: what you're applying for and where you saw it. Middle: your qualifications and relevant experience. Final paragraph: express enthusiasm and availability for interview.

**Tip.** Tense tip: use present simple for current skills ("I am a reliable person"), past simple for past experience ("I worked for..."), present perfect continuous for ongoing activities ("I have been studying..."). Mixing these correctly shows B2 grammar range.

### Letter to the Editor

You respond to an article or comment published in a newspaper or magazine. You must reference the original publication, then agree or disagree with the arguments made. It is a classic exam task.

Standard e-mail header (To: editor@publication.example). Greeting: "Dear Sir or Madam," or "Dear Editor,". The first sentence must name the article, the publication and the date. Sign off with Yours faithfully + full name + town/city.

**Tip.** Make it personal and local: explain why you care about this issue and how it affects your community.

### E-mail of Enquiry / Requesting Information

You want information about something – a product, a service, a course, an event, or a programme. You must be specific about what information you need.

Standard e-mail header. State your purpose in the first sentence. Use indirect questions ("I would like to know whether..." rather than "Is there...?") for a more formal tone. Each paragraph covers one information request.

**Tip.** Indirect questions ("I would like to know whether...") are more formal than direct questions ("Is there...?"). Using them throughout shows good control of formal register and grammar.

**More online.** On the website this text type also has a second model text (“Complaint about a faulty online order”, ~250 words · formal) and a realistic borderline text with notes on where it loses marks: matura.bernhardgmeiner.com/email/